under its first prime minister, Atal Bihari Vajpayee, power clearly began to accrete in the government as opposed to the party, but also, at another level, with the prime minister and party vis-à-vis the RSS. This was an organic process, but it was interrupted by the BJP's defeat in the general election of May 2004.

In the Modi period, however, the BJP has not only twice secured national electoral majorities, it has followed up these triumphs by vastly expanding its presence in the body politic in a way that few in the Sangh or the BJP would have imagined possible even at the turn of the century. While explaining how, why and when this shift unfolded, this chapter also explores possible shifts in the relationship between Nagpur and Delhi.

Between 2014 and 2020, the BJP created a robust organisational structure of its own at the ground level. In its expansion, it has overtaken the Chinese Communist Party (CCP). This massive expansion of the party base, in fact, replicates many organisational techniques of the RSS. It is important to note that China is a one-party state and Communist Party membership is a prerequisite for career advancement, whereas India is a multi-party democracy. In that sense, the BJP's accomplishment within a democratic framework has come against greater odds.

BJP leaders often exult about their party being the largest political party in the world.[9] Critics, on the other hand, tended to either not believe the membership numbers or dismissed the party's organisational growth as inconsequential—as only a vote-gathering machine that somehow comes into play only during election time. Yet, this structural and organisational transformation has been a fundamental enabler of its political power. Not only did district-level expansion help the BJP upend several traditional assumptions of politics in many states, it also fundamentally changed the balance of power between the party and the Sangh.

By 2020, the BJP's cadre network had dwarfed that of the RSS. It remained tied to the Sangh for ideological reasons, but structurally, it was not quite so dependent on the RSS to mobilise votes. If anything, the RSS was now more dependent on the BJP.

Consider this: in August 2014, when Amit Shah became BJP president, the party claimed to have 35 million members.[10] The CCP,